

Tuition Reimbursement Program

Eligibility

Full-time employees with at least 6 months of tenure are eligible for tuition reimbursement for courses related to their current role or a reasonable career path at Contoso Corp, as determined jointly by the employee and their manager. Part-time employees are not eligible for this specific program, though they remain eligible for the separate professional development stipend described in the Learning and Development policy.

Reimbursement Amount

Contoso Corp reimburses up to \$5,250 per calendar year for tuition, required textbooks, and course fees, upon proof of a passing grade (C or better, or Pass in pass/fail courses). Amounts above \$5,250 in a calendar year are reimbursed but treated as taxable income per IRS rules on employer education assistance, and Payroll will withhold applicable taxes from the portion above the threshold.

Approval Process

Submit the Tuition Reimbursement Pre-Approval Form to your manager and HR before the course start date; reimbursement requests without prior approval will be denied regardless of the grade earned, since the pre-approval step is what confirms the course is genuinely job-related before Contoso Corp commits to reimbursing it.

Repayment on Departure

Employees who voluntarily resign within 12 months of receiving tuition reimbursement must repay the reimbursed amount on a prorated basis, as outlined in the Tuition Reimbursement Agreement signed at approval time — for example, an employee who resigns 6 months after receiving reimbursement repays 50% of the amount received.

Repayment is not required if the employee is involuntarily terminated without cause, or if they leave due to a qualifying medical hardship documented with HR; the repayment obligation exists specifically to discourage using the benefit and then immediately resigning, not to penalize departures outside the employee's control.

Covered Program Types

Eligible programs include undergraduate and graduate degree programs, professional certifications directly relevant to the employee's role (for example, a cloud certification for an engineer), and

accredited online courses; unaccredited bootcamps are reviewed case by case and are not automatically covered the way accredited coursework is.

Denial Appeals

An employee whose pre-approval request is denied may appeal once, in writing, to a review panel made up of one HR representative and one representative from Learning and Development, who were not involved in the original decision; the panel's decision on appeal is final.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I use tuition reimbursement for a program outside the United States? Yes, as long as the institution is internationally accredited and the coursework meets the same current-role-or-reasonable-career-path standard applied to domestic programs; currency conversion for reimbursement uses the exchange rate on the date of your payment.

What if I fail a single course in an otherwise multi-course program? Only the failed course is denied reimbursement; passing courses in the same program remain eligible, since eligibility is evaluated course by course, not for the program as a single unit.

Roles and Responsibilities

The employee's manager confirms the course is relevant to the employee's role or reasonable career path. HR verifies eligibility and processes the pre-approval. Payroll disburses reimbursement upon proof of a passing grade and applies applicable tax withholding for amounts above the annual IRS-favorable threshold.

Time Off for Coursework

Tuition reimbursement does not include paid time off to attend class or study; employees are expected to schedule coursework around work hours where possible, or use standard PTO for any classes that unavoidably conflict with the work schedule. Employees pursuing an employer-requested certification (as opposed to a personal career-development choice) may be granted paid study time at their manager's discretion, tracked separately from PTO.

Program Funding Cap and Prioritization

The tuition reimbursement program has an overall annual company-wide budget; in the rare event that approved requests in a given year would exceed that budget, Learning and Development prioritizes requests tied to a documented business-critical skill gap over general career-development requests, though this cap has not been reached in any prior program year.

